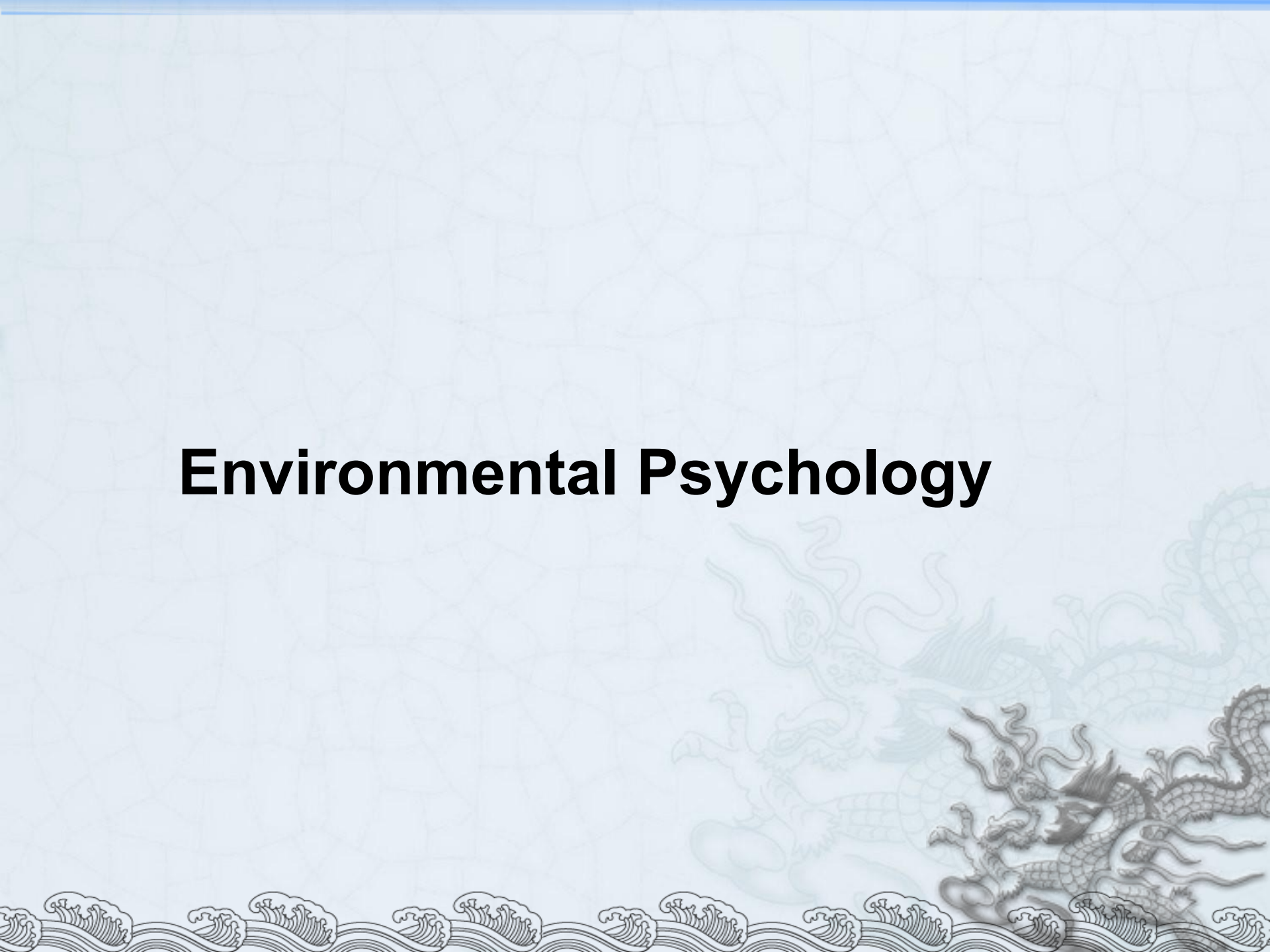
Environmental Psychology



Lecture five

Personal space and Environmental preference

Part One

- Personal space

Part Two

- Assessing the scene/environment

Imagine you are on a planet quite different from ours in some way. Where the people to walk right up to others, even strangers, and to stand right against them.

When waiting for a bus, they don't mind touching each other if there are enough spaces. Individuals simply form a mass of bodies instead of distributing themselves evenly and maintaining space between each person.

- The best way to explain **personal space** may be to ask you to place yourself in these situations – scenarios in which you are too close to someone.
- A simple definition of personal space was referring to an area with invisible boundaries surrounding a person body into which intruders may not come. – *Robert Sommer.*

Personal space

- The term “personal space” was coined by Katz. It also has roots in biology.
- An overload interpretation of why we maintain an interpersonal distance between ourselves and other is that such spacing is necessary to avoid overstimulation.
- According to this notion, too close a proximity to others causes us to be bombarded with excessive **social or physical stimuli**.
- The distance between individuals determines the quality and quantity of stimulation that is exchanged.
- Distance communicates information about the type of relationship between individuals.



- Personal space is not really personal but inter-personal, existing only when we interact with others.

Personal space determinant

- Two primary functions to personal space.
  - First, it has a protective function and serves as buffer against potential emotional and physical threats (e.g., too much stimulation, over arousal leading to stress, insufficient privacy, too much intimacy, physical attacks by others).
  - Second function is communication. The distance we maintain from others determines which sensory communication channels (e.g., smell, touch, visual input, verbal input).
- What determine the size of the personal space we prefer to maintain between ourselves and others?
- One determinant is the situation (i.e., who we are with and what we are doing).
- The other is the individual difference. Some individual habitually preserve minimal personal space zones, while others maintain relatively large personal space zones.

- Individual differences in spatial behavior probably reflect different learning experiences concerning the amount of space necessary to fulfill the protective and communicative functions.



Situation: just taking a picture with a local donkey



Situation: working together (a family)



Chinese eating and chatting in a limited space



Affectionate behavior of a couple


PENTAX
OK
火锅
麦当劳
SILK
丝绸商厦
TCL
VICHY

Personal space and human behavior

- What happens when individuals deliberately invade others' space or innocently choose inappropriate interpersonal distances?

- If you ever had your personal space invaded, you probably felt at least a short burst of emotion.
- For example, in a crowded elevator – some negative emotion usually surfaces.

- Appropriate distance in a given situation is associate with positive or neutral affect, but too-close and too-far distances lead to a bad feeling.

- When friends come very close, positive rather than negative feelings often result, but when the invader is a stranger, particularly a male stranger, negative feelings are aroused.







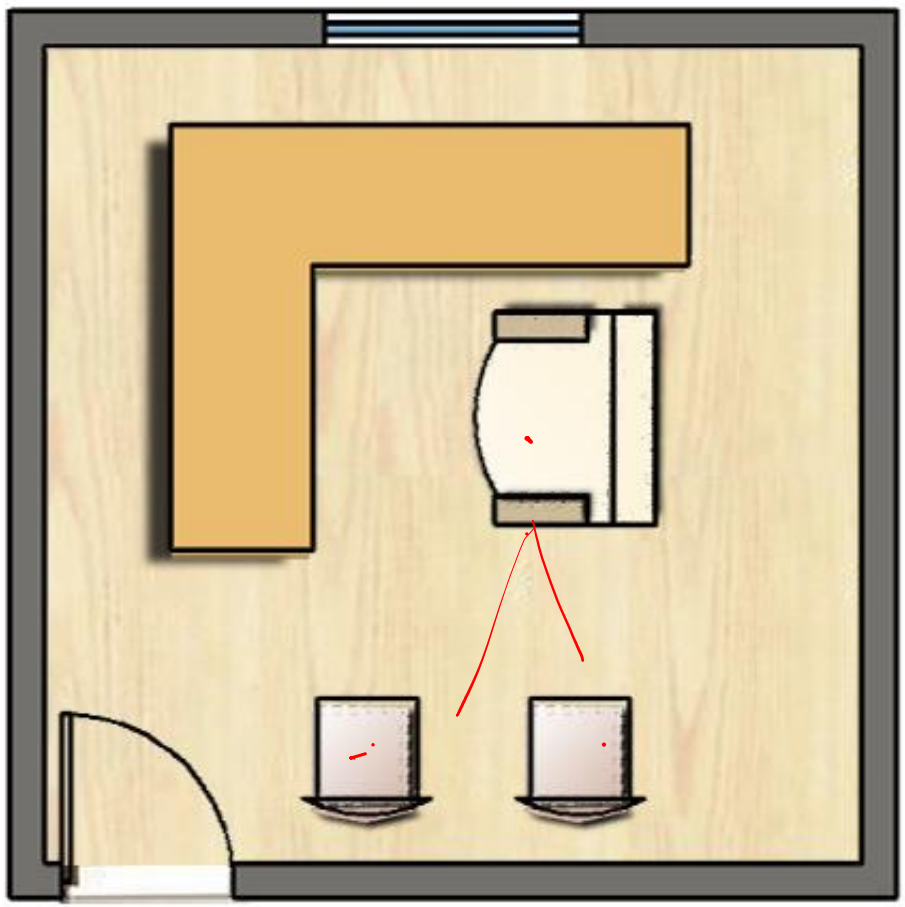


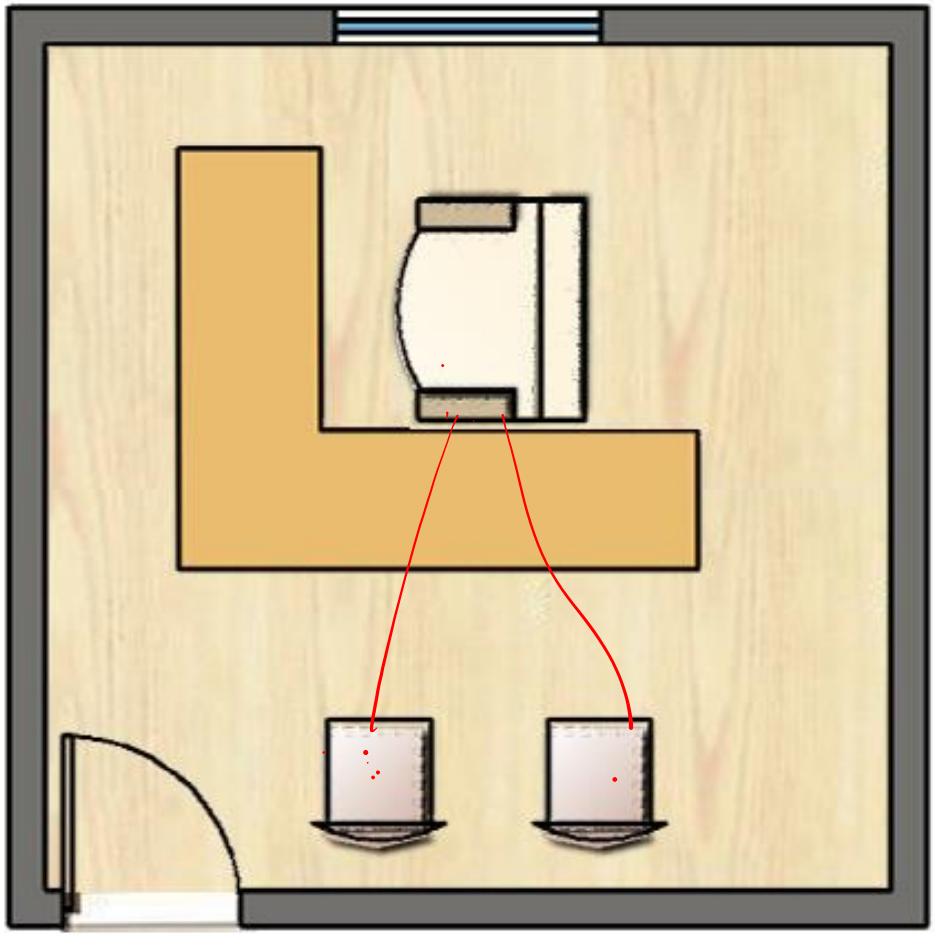




Personal space in public spaces

Personal space in an office room





Personal space is a fundamental determinant of how we perceived and evaluate beauty of the environment.

Landscape assessment, Aesthetics, and preference

- Suppose we are building a new condos in a resort area. Current residents do not want to detract from any scenic view they already have; Perspective occupants will want as scenic a view as possible; Designers do not want them to detract from the entire setting.

- Questions: What makes a scene attractive?

- Is a scene more valued if a forest contained? If so, should the trees be large, small or mixed size? Should the forest cover…..? Does a rustic barn enhance the scene or detract from it? What if the electric utility needs to …….?





- Historically, our aesthetic assessment of views to the surrounding environment have varied with time.
- Most of the eastern US was actually vast forest land before European settlers and later Americans began clearing it for farming.
- The prairies of the central US were fenced for ranching and cultivated for farming.
- Today, the trend is toward a "back to nature" philosophy in which we preserve rather than conquer the natural environment.
- Due to our current "back to nature" tendencies, principles of scenic for more natural environments do not apply very well to the built environment. Indeed, on the average, scenes of the built environment are valued less than scenes of more natural environment.
- Three broad approaches to assessing scenic environments***: descriptive approach***, used by landscape architects; ***physical-perceptual approach***, identify concrete physical objects contributing to perceived value; ***psychological approach***, based on subjective judgment.

Descriptive Systems of Scenic Value

Dominance principles** (aesthetic laws)**:

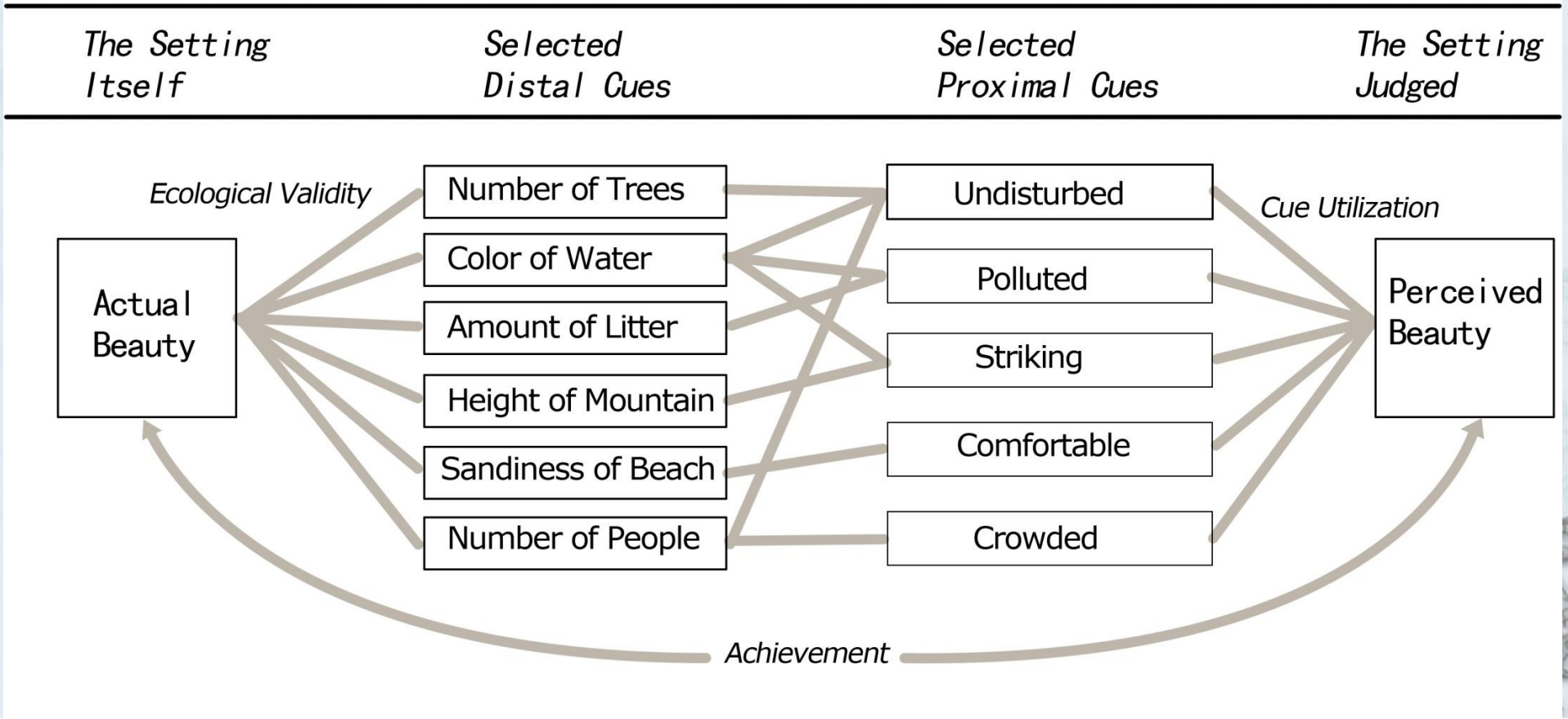
- ***Enframement***: tall trees in the foreground "framing" the distance scene of a pasture.

- ***Convergence***: two or more lines coming together in a scene.

- ***Contrast***: marked differences in line, form, color or texture; *the smooth texture of a pasture might contrast with the rough texture of a rocky coastline*.

Physical-perceptual approach to scenic value

- The psychological approach uses not physical components of the scene to predict its value, but rather uses the psychological organization of the elements in the scene (complexity, ambiguity, *spaciousness*, uniqueness, another panel judges the quality or beauty of the scene).



- **Environmental aesthetics**: the search for beauty in environment; how we make judgments of beauty – preference (nature, background, culture, physiological & psychological effects).

Psychological Approach to scenic value: who evaluates it



Aesthetic assessment

- Some environments evoke **awe** while others may suggest **informality and comfort**.

- The design of churches may seek to dwarf humans, and therefore suggest the proper relationship between people and their deity. Many churches are large, built seemingly for giants, awe-inspiring. A family restaurant may be built to seeking to welcome people by implying a “homey” environment.

- The aesthetic quality of the built environment can be influential as natural beauty. The problem is that aesthetic considerations in design often operate contrary to behavioral ones. Some of the most beautiful structures are also among the most impractical.

- There is evidence that aesthetics may be important in determining behavior.

- Studies of images of urban areas suggest that aesthetic qualities influence people’s ability to find their way through a cityscape (Lynch).

- Aesthetic qualities can reduce the monotony of the city and maintain gratifying levels of stimulation.





- No air condition


EXIT
EXIT
MYER
BAKU
BAKU


EXIT
MYER
BAKU
BAKU





End of the Fifth Lecture

Thanks for attention

Any questions? (leilayu@hit.edu.cn)